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Artificial Intelligence

Beiersdorf driving AI innovations

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Beiersdorf using artificial intelligence strategically - an interview with Dirk Ploss, Senior Innovation Manager

Beiersdorf is one of Germany's leading companies and is increasingly focusing on artificial intelligence innovations. Data-driven technology is now key to product development and optimising internal procedures. In an interview with Hamburg News, Dirk Ploss, Senior Innovation Manager at Beiersdorf in Hamburg, explains the company's strategic use of AI and risks including ethical issues and reliability that have to be overcome.

Hamburg News: Generative AI is being hailed as both groundbreaking and hyped. Where do you position the technology in this field of tension?

Dirk Ploss: Both perspectives are certainly justified. On the one hand, it really is one of the biggest **transformation machines** in decades. The potential increases in productivity and efficiency are enormous. On the other hand, AI is often simply misused as a sales-promoting label, not to mention so-called wrapper apps (apps that provide AI models such as Chat GPT, Dall-e etc. for specific use case). More than 6,000 new AI tools flooded the market in the first half of 2023 alone, which is quite significant.

Hamburg News: What risks does the world of work face in this context?

Ploss: Reliability, ethics and using the time saved sensibly. Reliability focuses on how much AI hallucinates, whether it provides real sources or invents them and the extent of biased training data. **Ethics** refer to aspects such as diversity, handling personal data and the liability of platforms. And gains in productivity should not be used mainly to reduce the number of jobs, but to make work more humane and meaningful.

Hamburg News: You once said: "I see a risk in not taking a risk." Does that apply to AI and what risks do you see here?

Ploss: Yes, definitely. Every new technology holds both risks and opportunities. I wouldn't dismiss ChatGPT's technology by saying "it doesn't work" just because it hallucinated at first. On the contrary, the risk of being left behind or being punished by the shareholders and losing the best brains is far greater than losing time and money because the AI results are not fully developed. I can only advise you to be aware of the risks - especially the technological, communicative, legal and financial risks.

Hamburg News: How long has Beiersdorf been using AI and what goals are you pursuing?

Ploss: We have been working with AI models and applications for a very long time, e.g., in analytics, formula development and toxicology. We launched an intelligent chatbot in 2019, and had an internal

employees. For us, AI is not simply an accelerator, but above all an improver.

Felina Wellner: Has AI changed your role as an innovation manager?

Ploss: Yes, quite a lot actually. My team and I are taking on more and more pilot functions because the specialist departments cannot spend all day dealing with every new AI. We look around, we try things out, we check for potential risks and opportunities, we make recommendations. Traditional innovation management is also changing tremendously as a result of AI. Idea generation, idea evaluation, research, idea enrichment, process optimisation, formula development, communication have to be rethought.

Dirk Ploss, Senior Innovation Manager at Beiersdorf

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Internal and external capacities

Ploss: You definitely need both. You need generalists within the company who can think in terms of convergence, use cases, risks and opportunities. External specialists are brought on board on a selective basis. If you rely on only one of the two, you will be left behind or become too dependent.

Hamburg News: How important are Hamburg's startups and research institutions for Beiersdorf?

Ploss: They play quite a big role already, and will play an even bigger role in future. Beiersdorf has a very long history of open innovation. We have been active in corporate venture capital for a number of years and have invested in startups that **collaborate** with us to research and implement strategic initiatives. In addition, **close links with research and science** have always been important to us. Many other areas of co-operation have been added recently, such as the very broad field of sustainability in addition to AI innovations.

Hamburg News: What technological developments will characterise the corporate world in the coming years?

Ploss: Innovation and product life cycles will change drastically through the use of key technologies, including generative AI, quantum computing and spatial computing. They lead to **personalised, immersive experiences** and revolutionise procedures. Specialised and generalised agents will change the value chain permanently. Consumers will delegate a significant proportion of their purchases to shopping agents, retailers will develop flexible, agent-supported supply chains and manufacturers like us will use agents along the entire value chain - from innovation, purchasing and production to logistics and marketing.

Interview by Felina Wellner.
fw/sb/pb

Read our overview of Hamburg-based companies' successful AI stories.

Sources and further information

- beiersdorf.com
- dirkploss.de
- atvisio.de | Podcast Beiersdorf

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